

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Evacuating with pets

EVACUATION SHELTER / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Take pets when you can evacuate safely, using a carrier or lead and a destination that accepts them. Keep food, water, medicines, identification and veterinary information together. Do not delay escape into immediate danger or reenter a hazardous building for an animal.

Do now.

**Contain animals early**

01

Use a secure carrier or lead before loading or opening doors. Distress and noise can cause animals to run.

**Confirm the destination**

02

Ask whether pets are accepted and what documents or carriers are needed. Make a backup arrangement with a trusted person.

**Pack basic care**

03

Take normal food, safe water, medicines, waste supplies and a familiar blanket if readily available. Include pet water in the household total.

**Keep identification current**

04

Use a tag and a recent photo, and check microchip contact details before emergencies. Keep veterinary records privately.

**Avoid unsafe rescue**

05

Tell reachable responders where an animal may be, but do not return to fire, floodwater or active danger yourself.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use a trusted host or verified animal-care arrangement rather than assuming public shelters accept pets. Keep the family and animals together where safe and feasible.

Watch for.

A service animal and a pet may have different accommodation rules. Never leave animals in a hot vehicle while arranging shelter.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: contain animals early. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. A service animal and a pet may have different accommodation rules. Never leave animals in a hot vehicle while arranging shelter.

Keep essentials within reach.

For evacuating with pets, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Use a trusted host or verified animal-care arrangement rather than assuming public shelters accept pets. Keep the family and animals together where safe and feasible. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Check animals regularly for overheating, cold and distress in transport. Keep them restrained in crowded temporary accommodation and maintain hygiene.

First decision: Contain animals early

Use a secure carrier or lead before loading or opening doors. Distress and noise can cause animals to run. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Use a trusted host or verified animal-care arrangement rather than assuming public shelters accept pets. Keep the family and animals together where safe and feasible. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

A service animal and a pet may have different accommodation rules. Never leave animals in a hot vehicle while arranging shelter. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Take pets when you can evacuate safely, using a carrier or lead and a destination that accepts them. Keep food, water, medicines, identification and veterinary information together. Do not delay escape into immediate danger or reenter a hazardous building for an animal. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For evacuating with pets, keep the specific hazard in view: A service animal and a pet may have different accommodation rules. Never leave animals in a hot vehicle while arranging shelter.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Avoid unsafe rescue. Tell reachable responders where an animal may be, but do not return to fire, floodwater or active danger yourself. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov · Pets and animals](https://www.ready.gov/pets)

<https://www.ready.gov/pets>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/pet-evacuation/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.